

Three Pitfalls — Reference + Example Pack

Day 2 · Activity 1 handout. The three standard North Star pitfalls, plus eight anonymized public-company NS candidates to score before you diagnose your own.

The three standard pitfalls

PITFALL	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	THE TELL
1. Vanity dressed up	A number that sounds north-star-ish but isn't	Customers don't feel it directly when this number moves
2. Leading-indicator confusion	A metric that's actually a KPI or op-signal in disguise	A team can move it without the customer being any better off long-term
3. Gameable target	A target with no usage-quality gate	A team can hit it with sales tactics or notification spam

A well-formed North Star has been challenged against all three and survived.

The example pack (8 NS candidates, anonymized)

For each card, assign **0, 1, 2, or 3** pitfalls present and write a one-line argument.

#	NS CANDIDATE	COMPANY TYPE
1	"Monthly Active Riders"	Ride-share
2	"Total Bookings Volume"	Hospitality marketplace
3	"Hours Watched per Day"	Streaming service
4	"Songs Saved to Library"	Music streaming
5	"Daily Active Users"	Social network
6	"Annual Recurring Revenue"	Vertical SaaS
7	"Successful Deliveries per Active Customer per Month"	Logistics SaaS
8	"Queries Resolved without Human Escalation"	Customer support SaaS

Deliverable

A scored card pack: each card tagged with 0–3 pitfalls and a one-line argument. Identify **one clean-bill-of-health pick** and **one all-three pick**.

"We give [X] a clean bill of health because [reason]. We give [Y] all three pitfalls because [reason]."